



Behind the Hail Mary that saved RFK bill

D.C. mayor worked with opponents to pass stadium legislation

BY MEAGAN FLYNN, ERIN COX AND SAM FORTIER

It was 1 a.m. Saturday, and D.C. Mayor Muriel E. Bowser was sitting at the foot of her bed glued to C-SPAN, waiting to see whether the U.S. Senate would deliver the city one of its greatest economic development opportunities this generation in the final hours of the congressional session.

Earlier that evening, all hope appeared lost that Congress would pass the RFK bill, allowing D.C. to redevelop the land surrounding the defunct RFK football stadium, possibly into a new home for the Washington Commanders.

But hope was not lost for Bowser (D), team executives and the city's allies in Congress. On Friday night, they launched a feverish, long-shot bid to push the bill through the Senate under unanimous consent, a procedure that would require all senators present to agree to let it pass.

One by one, Bowser and her allies tackled objections from the bill's chief opponents to carve out a last-minute path to success in the Senate, communicating with everyone from a D.C. home-rule nemesis to Maryland senators and the secretary of the Air Force, according to interviews with more than a dozen people involved in the negotiations or with direct knowledge of them, many of whom spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss private negotiations.

While Maryland pursued a transfer of National Guard fighter jets from D.C., the city made a promise to another chief opponent, Sen. Mike Lee (R-Utah), as things came down to the wire: If a stadium were built, the city would kick in funds to spruce up National Park Service land in the city, according to Bowser officials.

At 1:15 a.m. Saturday, Senate Majority Leader Charles E. Schumer

SEE STADIUM ON A5

For Christians, a new tempo in post-Assad Syria



SALWAN GEORGES/THE WASHINGTON POST

Security forces with Syria's nascent Interior Ministry flank musicians from St. George's Syriac Orthodox Church during a Christmas Day parade in Damascus. The Christian minority's celebration took place against a backdrop of hope after the fall of Bashar al-Assad and unease toward the nation's new Islamist leaders. **Story, A8**

Israel demolishing northern Gaza, imagery shows

BY MIRIAM BERGER, IMOGEN PIPER, HAZEM BALOUSHA AND EVAN HILL

Israel is carrying out mass demolitions and erecting military fortifications in residential areas of northern Gaza where tens of thousands of Palestinians have been forced to flee their homes, according to satellite imagery, verified videos and interviews.

The Israel Defense Forces said that it launched an Oct. 5 air and ground assault in the northernmost parts of Gaza — Jabalya, Beit Lahia and Beit Hanoun — to oust Hamas militants who had regrouped there and that the operation would “continue as

long as necessary.”

More than 100,000 Palestinians have been driven from the affected areas over the past 11 weeks, according to the United Nations, leaving an estimated 30,000 to 50,000 people — less than an eighth of the prewar population. Hardly any aid has reached the area since the beginning of October due to Israeli restrictions, humanitarian groups say, and experts warn that famine may have already taken hold in some places.

As areas are emptied of Palestinians, Israeli forces have demolished entire neighborhoods, established military fortifications and built new roads, according to a Washington Post analysis of

Palestinians are forced to flee as the IDF carves out a military corridor

high-resolution satellite images. The visual evidence shows almost half of Jabalya refugee camp was demolished or cleared between Oct. 14 and Dec. 15, connecting a preexisting road in the west to an expanded vehicle track in the east — carving out a military axis that stretches from the sea to the border fence with Israel.

The establishment of this corridor, the clearing of tracts of land on either side of it and the con-

struction of square-shaped protected outposts resemble the IDF's transformation of the Netzarim Corridor, a strategic Israeli military zone in the center of Gaza, analysts said. While Israeli forces cut the Netzarim Corridor through a lightly populated, largely agricultural area, Israel's operations in the north are centered in dense urban neighborhoods — effectively destroying northern Palestinian cities.

While the military has given no public explanation for its clearing and fortifying activities in the north, analysts said the newly created axis could separate the far north from Gaza City, allowing Israel to create a buffer zone

SEE GAZA ON A9

Judges dig in, limiting Trump

GOP CRIES FOUL ON RETIREMENT PIVOTS

Political jockeying over judiciary at fever pitch

BY TOBI RAJI

Three federal judges appointed by Democrats have changed their retirement plans ahead of President-elect Donald Trump's return to the White House, with a fourth being warned on the Senate floor not to follow suit.

It is rare in the federal court system for judges to retract declarations of senior status, a form of semi-retirement that creates a vacancy on the court. Key Republicans have sharply criticized the decisions, which ensure that Trump — who pushed the courts substantially to the right during his first term in office — will not immediately get the chance to name successors for those judicial seats.

Legal experts see the judges' actions as part of the broader political jockeying over a federal court system whose judges have lifetime appointments and whose rulings can shape policy over multiple administrations.

Senate Democrats raced to confirm as many nominees of President Joe Biden as possible after the election, knowing that they would not be confirmed once a Republican-majority Senate is sworn in early next year, and that Trump will soon begin making his own nominations. The last two confirmations came Friday, leaving Biden with 235 judicial appointments, one more than Trump had during his first term.

On Monday, Biden vetoed the Judges Act, which would have created dozens of new judgeships to ease growing caseloads. The bill had bipartisan support in the Senate this summer, but House Republicans balked at passing it until Trump won the election.

The judiciary's impact on American life has grown in recent

SEE COURT ON A4

The street where Helene never ended

As winter sets in, the few residents left try to build new lives amid the wreckage of their old ones

BY BRADY DENNIS AND SARAH KAPLAN

SWANNANOVA, N.C. — Light streams through the empty windows of gutted houses as the sun rises on what remains of Edwards Avenue. A breeze swirls the brown river silt that still coats nearly every surface on the street. The only break in the silence comes from the call of a Carolina wren.

“It's like a ghost town,” says Tissica Schoch, one of a handful of people left living here nearly three months after Hurricane Helene.

When the storm arrived on that Friday morning in late September, this once-bustling street of about 40 homes became a scene of terror and loss: The Swannanoa River roared as it swallowed everything in its path. Neighbors screamed for help as they scurried to attics and swam out of windows, desperate to keep their heads above the torrent. Alarms triggered by the rising water shrieked into the howling wind.

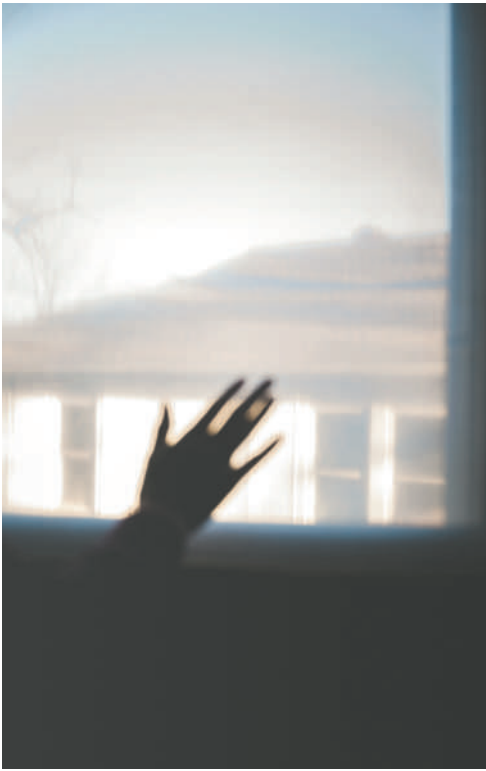
Then came the chaotic aftermath: the cacophony of shovels and dump trucks as waterlogged houses were stripped to their studs. The streams of volunteers who descended to rip out drywall, clear mud-caked rooms and sort through debris for family heirlooms. The thrum of anxiety as survivors sought clean water and new clothing and somewhere else to live.

Now winter has set in, bringing a stillness

SEE HELENE ON A6



ABOVE LEFT: Tony Burgin celebrated his 18th birthday at his home days before Hurricane Helene upended his life. ABOVE RIGHT: Christine Hart, 40, holds her hand against her home's window, through which she and her family escaped the storm's wrath.



PHOTOS BY HANNAH YOON FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

‘Prosperity gospel’ led some Latinos to Trump

Belief set has overtaken traditional theologies centered on the poor

BY MICHELLE BOORSTEIN

ALLENTOWN, PA. — The Lehigh Valley Barbershop was bustling with the next generation of American strivers. The mood among the young men, mostly first- or second-generation immigrants from Puerto Rico and the Dominican Republic, was hopeful. Their candidate, Donald Trump, had just won the presidential election.

Sitting in high-end silver chairs, the young men talked about the businesses they had built, or would build. That would be more possible, they hoped, with the return of Trump, someone to whom they could relate — a businessman who has made mistakes, they said, but still keeps striving.

“Kamala said, ‘Trump is for the rich, I fight for the poor.’ But I don't want to be low-class — I

hope that's not a bad way to say it. But I don't want to be there,” said Christian Pion, 31, referring to Vice President Kamala Harris. He became a U.S. citizen last year, a decade after coming to the United States from the Dominican Republic, and cast his first presidential ballot for Trump. “God doesn't want you to be poor.”

Next to him, his best friend, Willy J. Castillo, 39, who owns the shop and others, worked the register as he talked about Trump's drive to succeed, overcome and survive. Castillo, who also voted for Trump, identifies with that: “The Bible says ‘God helps those who help themselves,’ right?”

The mix of hope, drive for success and belief in a God who rewards faith, sometimes with financial accomplishments, has become dominant across the United States and Latin America, experts on Latino religion say. The belief system is sometimes called “seed faith,” “health and wealth gospel” or “prosperity gospel.”

In the past half-century, driven by larger-than-life pastors, it has overtaken other more-traditional

SEE GOSPEL ON A4

IN THE NEWS

Hanukkah cheer The Capital Jewish Museum prepared for the Festival of Lights with family activities and community service. **B1**

Family detentions set to return Parents in the United States illegally could be deported with or without their children, Trump's “border czar” said in an interview. **A2**

THE NATION The bald eagle was not officially the national bird. One man's efforts have changed that. **A3**
Squirrels have been filmed hunting and eating tiny rodents, leaving scientists perplexed. **A5**

THE WORLD King Charles III gave his holiday message from a former hospital chapel. **A10**

THE ECONOMY Should you trust an AI-assisted doctor? The Post tried one out. **A11**

THE REGION The Senate adjourned without confirming 10 judicial nominees for D.C.'s local courts, to city leaders' dismay. **B1**
All-cash deals dominated D.C. home sales this year, accounting for more than a quarter of purchases, the highest rate in a decade. **B1**

STYLE Oddly paced and narratively inert, the second season of Netflix's “Squid Game” weakens the impact of the first. **C1**
Hope Walz, daughter of Tim Walz, uses TikTok to grieve post-election and plan her next steps, and many viewers are doing the same. **C1**

A 137-year-old weekly newspaper that has long documented rural life in the southeastern corner of Colorado faced extinction until readers stepped in to keep it afloat. **C1**

LOCAL LIVING The Local Living section is off this week.

BUSINESS NEWS.....A11
COMICS.....C5
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A12
TELEVISION.....C4
WORLD NEWS.....A8

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